

Special Events Center

Hall of Fame finally has a home

By DON HENRY
Assistant sports editor

It all began about 25 years ago with Andy Cohen: The El Paso Athletic Hall of Fame's first member.

But, for a quarter of a century, there was no place of honor for Cohen and his later athletic compadres to walk ... not even in an alleyway, much less a carpeted Hall.

But, it's finally changing. It'll be only a matter of weeks before the greats of El Paso will have a lasting home for their honors. And you have to give the credit to a pair of Texas Aggies — no joke.

Now in the hands of artisans are individual plaques bearing the names and pictures of more than half of the more than 80 members of the El Paso Athletic Hall of Fame, and within weeks, these remembrances will be mounted in the new "home," the concourse of UTEP's Special Events Center.

And yearly, as additional El Pasoans are honored, plaques in their honor will be added to the display.

The El Paso Hall of Fame is no slouch, either — not with such nationally known athletes on the list as Lee Trevino ... Willie Shoemaker ... Don Maynard ... Don Haskins ... Mike Brumelow.

But, after their names were read (at an annual banquet), their achievements chronicled to an accompanying round of applause silenced, there was nothing ... no mementoes, no further recognition.

"All these years, there was no permanent spot where these people could be honored," commented John "Pinkey" Edwin, a Texas Aggie, El Pasoan, veterinarian, trap shooter, and Hall of Famer — and not necessarily in that order.

"Over the years, people have suggested

places for a Hall of Fame ... in the airport ... at City Hall ... but nothing was ever done."

Then, this year, Edwin was elected president of the Hall. Being an Aggie and with the coming of another Aggie (Dr. Haskell Monroe) as president of UTEP, Edwin asked Monroe: Was there a place on the University campus where the Hall could be housed? And Edwin suggested SEC.

"Dr. Monroe was agreeable to it," related Edwin, "so he talked to (UTEP Athletic Director) Jim Bowden and (Basketball Coach) Don Haskins. That got the ball rolling."

Straight into the SEC foyer.

Now, Edwin is in the process of rounding up pictures of Hall of Famers to be reproduced on plaques which will be mounted on the walls of the concourse.

The engravings will bear the name of the person, her or his sport or field of service (coach, administrator, media), and UTEP, if they had any connection whatsoever with the University.

"We didn't want to go into all the achievements," said Edwin. "You get some of those people — like Trevino — and the plaque wouldn't hold all their accomplishments."

Twenty five years ago, a quartet of El Pasoans who had watched and chronicled the city's athletes came up with the idea of a Hall of Fame.

Former Times sports editor Chuck Whitlock, Bob Ingram of the Herald-Post, radio-man John Phelan and sports enthusiast-businessman Chris Fox initiated the Hall and in 1955 selected Andy Cohen, the former major league manager (for one day) and player, ex-minor league manager and ex-Miner baseball coach as the first inductee.

The group selected tennis player Margaret

Varnier a year later, and the list has grown from there.

Edwin was inducted in 1975, along with Trevino, Karen Linton, Robert Carson and Phelan.

Now, a 50-person committee handles selections, from categories of athletes, news media, and coach-administration, with a main qualification is 10 years residency in the city.

"We can select with less than 10 yers, but it has to be someone with qualifications of quote such magnitude unquote to merit it, and it takes a vote of the committee for this. So far, we haven't selected anyone this way," said Edwin.

But for Edwin, the fun of the current project — now that a permanent home has been found — is locating pictures for the plaques.

"This really has been fun," remarked Edwin, "not only locating the pictures, but the people. We're letting every member choose the picture they want, and some of them are really something."

"For instance, (coaches) Mack Saxon and Harry Phillips were in a picture together, made in 1929, and we can separate that and use it for both guys."

In most cases, Famers have volunteered to pay the \$75 price for their plaques, but the Hall is handling all others.

"We're hoping to have some of the plaques up (in the SEC) by the first of December, or about the time the Miners start playing basketball. Then, when they're all up (sometime this winter), we hope to get as many of the Hall members and their families as possible and recognize them, at a Miner basketball game," said Edwin.

"Bowden and UTEP officials are working on that."

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